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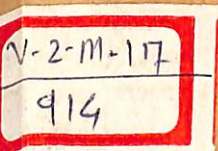
THE PRINCIPLES AND
PHILOSOPHY
OF
THE BHOODAN YAGNA

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SARVODAYA PRACHURALAYA, TANJORE.

PRICE FIVE ANNAS



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This is a collection of portions from the speeches of Acharya Vinoba Bhave on various occasions during his Bhoodan Yatra and at the Sarvodaya Sammelan at Bodh-Gaya in April 1954. They explain the basic principles, technique and philosophy behind the non-violent revolution of Bhoodan which is the first step towards the Sarvodaya Order of Society. They are arranged under the following heads :

1. THE BASIS OF BHOODAN YAGNA
2. SELF-DISCIPLINED FREE INDIA
3. THE WAY TO WORLD'S PEACE
4. THE THIRD FORCE OR JANA-SAKTHI
5. TOWARDS A STATE-FREE SOCIETY
6. THE ECONOMICS OF SAMPATTI-DAN

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SARVODAYA PRACHURALAYA,

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I

The Basis of Bhoodan

OUR work consists in changing the present social order from the very root. This is the secret of this Bhoodan campaign. That is why when people ask me whether this can be done by legislation alone, I reply in the negative. This is not a onesided movement. When it succeeds the State will change, the Government will change and the life-structure will change.

To the society which we seek to build up I have given the name 'Samyayogi Society'. I struck at this word from the Gita which teaches us to do unto others as we do unto ourselves. We should treat others in the same manner as we want to be treated by them. So also we must behave towards society as we aspire to be treated by it. When Hanuman met Ravana he placed before him the injustice of the latter's act in having stolen Rama's consort. He told him that he (Ravana) could easily see the error of his ways since he (Ravana) was himself a grahastha (householder). He asked him to visualise the situation in the event of his own wife being kidnapped.

In the Chapter on fasts ('roza'), the Holy Quran enjoins on all followers to observe fast during the month of Ramzan. Somebody raised a misgiving whether those who could not bear the pangs of hunger would be regarded as an outcast. The prophet spoke, "No, if on that day they feed a hungry man they would win the credit of a fast". Now what is grand about it? The grandeur lies in your feeling what it is to suffer from pangs of hunger when you must take it that your duty lies in alleviating others' hunger. Gita has given it the name of *Atmopamya* (like-Self). This is not something particular to Hinduism

alone. You will find it in all religions. This is termed the golden rule. In case one does not feel the pangs of hunger he cannot be enjoined to feed the hungry. If one does not feel the pangs of thirst he cannot be enjoined to slake the thirsty throat.

I ask the land-owners to imagine from their own experience the condition of those who own no land. I ask the property-owners to imagine from their experience the conditions of those who own no property. If you have any appreciation of their feeling it is enjoined upon you to distribute among them the extra that you have. This is your Dharma.

The most essential requisite of a *Samyayogi* social structure is that all land, all property, and all wealth should belong to society. Only Vishnu can be the lord of Lakshmi, a seat which you have usurped. Bhartruhari has said that to us Lakshmi is mother, and we are her children. On the contrary, to-day we aggrandise ourselves as her Lord. I feel this is injustice, and a denial of religion. It is not a single individual behaving thus, but the whole of society. Should somebody commit adultery it is his fault and not that of the society. But if the social structure be such that it grants the right of ownership of land to some, of ownership of property to others and so on, everybody would enjoy what he gets hold of. And all this is regarded sacred and holy! Now the priests of Vaidyanathdam assaulted me. When I pondered over it I felt that they believed that we were out to destroy religion and they were out to protect it by the force of arms. Where religion enjoys such sanctions irreligion gets entrenched very deep.

What I want to inculcate among the people is that our body is made from and of society and for the service of the society. Service is thus a debt on our shoulders which we have to repay. We are distinct from our body. So when we are not the owners or masters of even our body, how dare we claim our right on other things as land and property? Ganga loves all alike. She quenches the thirst of the lion as also of the cow. Should somebody claim his right upon such a beneficent Ganga, would we accept it? If none has a claim on the Ganga, how can we have on land or property?

I go on saying from village to village that if classes or differences had been dear to God's heart, He would not have provided everybody with one nose. He would have granted one nose to a poor man while ten or more to a minister. But he feels that everybody requires nose and should have equal right to breathe air. As none can claim ownership of air, water or sunshine, so also none can claim that of land. Should somebody claim it, that is due to wrong idea which is irreligious. Hence I have given it the name of moral revolution — *Dharma-pravartan*. I want to root out the wrong ideas and erect the new society on the basis of religious ideas.

It is why I demand one-sixth of land. There are some 5 crores of landless people in our country. For them we require five crores of acres, about one-sixth of good land available in India. In case these calculations come out to be incorrect I would demand again more land. For what I want is that there must be a complete redistribution of land and property, as also of power.

Today we are busy in national planning. In fact we require a village planning. People of the village should

exercise their own brain to do things. Should somebody err only one village would suffer. But when the stewardship of the whole country is entrusted to four or five persons the whole country has to suffer the consequence of their any single mistake. But this will not be so when power resides in the village itself. If one village commits a certain blunder another would not repeat it. Hence power should be distributed in every village. There must be decentralisation of power like the one set up by God. We do not want to imitate Russia or China in this. God does not reserve for Himself the store of wisdom, nor does He supply it according to individual needs. He distributes all unto all.

Still people have to co-operate among themselves. Co-operation is of two kinds. First is to give one's all and share with others. Second is that proverbial co-operation of the blind and the lame. Had the latter been the desired objective God would have bestowed four eyes to one, four ears to another and bid them co-operate. This amounts to a co-operative society of the disabled! But God has not ordained this variety of society. He has provided everybody with all things and made them able and bid them co-operate. In other words, the wisdom of all should form one whole. Of course He could have made man all-sufficient and all-able. But He felt that life would then lose all charm.

We have to build up a society in which every calling is equally paid. Every calling has an importance of its own. That one work should be valued more than another is an injustice. Take for instance the work of a train-signaller. What great responsibility this carries! A signaller's work is a responsibility of a type unique in itself.

It may be admitted that the responsibility implied in one work differs from that in another. But equal wages would have to be paid to all unless and until it is established that the one with a greater responsibility feels more hungry than the one with a lesser responsibility. It is wrong to pay according to the responsibility involved in a work or its extent.

In fact, our objective is three-fold. Firstly, power should be decentralised from village to village; secondly, everybody should have a right on land and property; thirdly, there should be no distinction in the matter of wages etc. With this aim in view I have introduced the lever of Bhoodan in order that a Samya-Yogi order may be established. Hence I go from village to village. People ask me why I would not apply 'pressure' over our Government to frame law accordingly. I am, in fact, not interested in it. What I am interested in, is in reducing the governmental authority itself and in the creation of a New Social Order. I have resorted to this problem of land with this objective.

We want to bring about an equilibrium or an equality in society. None can profit from an unequal and unbalanced society.

Samya-Yoga means 'levelling' the field. That we have to do. Ours is not merely to distribute land but to level up the mental values of the entire society. With this mental approach you go from village to village and explain the idea. Go with a complete confidence in the heart of every one you approach.

Self-Disciplined Free India

A Guide to the World

THE NEW LABOUR DAY OF INDIA

TODAY is 18th April, 1954. It is the 'May Day' for the labour-world of India. In memory of the hard sufferings of the labour-folk May Day is celebrated all over the world. In cities there are the labour-folk. They are there in the villages also. In cities they are organised and through their unions they make their voices heard. But what about those wage-earners of agriculture in the villages? They are at the bottom and are now the worst sufferers.

BHOODAN IN THE MIDST OF ELECTION BREEZE

It was on this very day that three years back I received the first gift of Bhoodan while touring in Telangana. I need not relate that incident here again. It got wide publicity through press and many have come to know of it. From that day onwards I have done as much propaganda as I could from village to village. I was working almost all alone in the first year. Our people will not accept new ideas all on a sudden. Yet I was surprised to find how quickly our people began to react to this new ideal behind Bhoodan. In Uttar Pradesh it was election time when I was touring. I had a few colleagues with me then. Some of them left me. Of course, I did permit them to go, and they went for election work. My condition then was exactly like that of a rich man who became absolutely poor and was left by his relations to himself alone to pull on. When the

election fight was at its height and heat, a few friends even requested me to suspend my programme of onward march for a couple of weeks. But I asked them, "Aren't you the people living on the banks of the rivers Jamuna and Ganga? Do these rivers ever stop flowing? If they don't, why should I be asked to stop?" And I proceeded on. People came in thousands, listened in rapt attention to the message and it went straight to their hearts. I was myself wondering at their enthusiasm. From there I came to your province of Bihar.

THE HISTORICAL STEP OF BIHAR CONGRESS COMMITTEE

A unique thing happened in this province. In all other provinces, the Congressmen and the Praja-Socialists voiced their sympathy for Bhoodan movement and did some work. But here in this province, the Provincial Congress Committee took a courageous and far-sighted step in accepting Bhoodan as their main work and issued a bold statement that they were out to collect the full quota of 32 lakhs for the province. They also appealed to all other parties in the province to co-operate with them in the work. The Praja-Socialist Party also of this province took a similar decision. This courageous step of these two major parties had its decided effect throughout the whole country. But the pledge should be fulfilled; then only the good influence created, will have beneficial results. Therefore it is the responsibility of one and all of this province to proceed on with the work with the maximum speed. I wish I may be allowed to proceed at the earliest to other provinces. I can go only if the work here is completed.

DONORS: THE BUTTER-MILK TO CURDLE THE MILK OF SOCIETY

A very hopeful atmosphere is created here in this province. None says 'no' when he is affectionately approached for *Bhoodan*. Every one says 'yes' if he is made to understand the ideal behind. Of course, some give more and some less. This is natural, for man will not be freed of his lust in one day. Yet the pleasant experiences so far I had, make me feel confident of the bright future of this province.

So far $2\frac{1}{2}$ lakhs of *danapatras* have been received in this Yagna. Within two or three days another half a lakh is expected. These three lakhs of gift-deeds speak that the message of the Yagna has gone into the hearts of three lakhs of people. One spoonful of butter-milk will quite suffice to convert a big pot of milk into curd. These three lakhs of people will act exactly like the one spoonful of butter-milk to convert the rest of the population. It is not at all difficult for these three lakhs to grow into thirty lakhs. When 100 people listen to the message, one *danapatra* comes. So 3 crores of people have heard the message. Once again I appeal to one and all in Bihar "Let every individual who possesses land offer his share to this Yagna".

MANIFESTATION OF GOD'S POWER

In Gokul—Brindhavan when Lord Krishna gave the suggestion to one and all of the inhabitants there to make use of their hand and sticks to raise the Govardhan mountain, all of them at once applied their full and joint strength. Imagine a mountain to be lifted by human

effort! The Lord was pleased to see their joint effort and He graced it by His touch and the mountain was lifted high. Here the people of Brindavan did the work in His name and the mere graceful touch of His fingers brought success to them. God's power at once manifests if the people's strength unites into one. Any new force manifesting in society is nothing but God's power. The strength in one when multiplied to the power of five is not equal to the simple total five; it goes beyond it and becomes five times five. Now the new strength manifesting in our society is nothing but the power of the One above. By Him and through Him alone, work is being done. His manifestation becomes evident only when the united co-operation of all is there. Any work receiving the co-operation of all becomes a Yagna.

BE NOT TRAITORS TO YOUR COUNTRY

When any misfortune or distress is there in the country a Yagna has to be performed. Our country is now in distress. Suffering is present everywhere. I don't imagine that any new misfortune has fallen. It is there already within. The conflict between capital and labour, the lack of the means of livelihood in the hands of the many crores of our people, the untouchability among the Harijans and caste people, the bickerings amongst the different creeds and religions, all these are in our midst. Under such conditions to save the country a Yagna is started. If 1 or 40 to 50 people alone participate in it, nothing by way of relief will result from it. So it becomes the duty of everyone to contribute his due share. He who refrains from such social Yagnas and thus fails to play his part, becomes a

traitor to his country, so would I declare. Our country, in this crisis, demands everyone to offer his *danapatra* to solve the huge problem of the land-hunger of the landless peasants.

DAN-PATRAS CENT PER CENT ONLY

I have been telling the people in every village that all those who own lands, whether they be small or big-holders or zamindars, should offer their *danapatras*. Even 99% will not suffice; cent per cent should be forthcoming. Then only it can be said that the message is accepted and success is achieved. Man is one who possesses a mind which can understand and realize. It is in this peculiar characteristic he differs from the beasts. A certain friend asked me, "You want 100 gift-deeds from all the 100 persons. What does it mean? Even in elections 70% or 80% votes is considered even more than sufficient, but you say that you should have 100%". Then I asked him "Please tell me what is the percentage you can fix for men who can avoid and escape death? If death demands 100% why not life also demand the same percentage?"

It has become now quite clear that once our people understand, they will not remain without offering *dan*. From what I have seen so far, I feel confident that this mission is bound to succeed. People in many villages have donated their entire land to this Yagna. Had anyone ever hoped that such things would happen? In Palamu district 10 to 12 villages offered their entire lands. Gopa Babu tells me that in Orissa some 15 to 16 villages executed gift-deeds of their entire lands. The Mangroth village in Uttar-Pradesh offered all the lands

of their village. Are the people of these villages angels or God's messengers? No, they are ordinary human beings quite like you and me. This new ideal has spread in them. The workers have gone to them and explained to them; and they have understood and acted.

REAL SWARAJ

Once a man understands an ideal he does not remain without acting. May be he takes some time, but that is a different affair. Man never feels happy unless he translates his thoughts into action. I feel and hope that when some people in our villages give all that belong to them, it becomes possible that others also will follow suit. Our country will become free then only when each and every individual of his own free will begins to offer his share. Swaraj does not merely mean the Government of our people. Swaraj means that every individual feels that the country is his, that nobody can oppress him nor will he oppress anyone, that no one can suppress him nor will he suppress anyone and that he is neither afraid of anyone, nor can he create fear in another. In such an atmosphere alone Swaraj would prevail. In such a State every individual becomes self-disciplined and does his work by himself without slaving for another.

Once more I appeal to you, "If you do this Yagna as I desire you to do, it will certainly have its own influence on the whole of India. If the people of India solve their land problem by the strength of their free will they will not only gain materially and morally but also will shine as a guide to the whole world."

The Way to World's Peace

NOW great is the responsibility that is cast on us—the people of India. We were feeling that the world was marching towards peace and it would choose that way alone in the end. But from the preparations that are going on today amongst the various nations, we feel that our hopes are belied and we fear that it may throw the world into a great conflagration of war. Of course the big leaders desire to do what they think and preach. We do not suspect their bonafides. America, Russia and also other nations, often state that there should be co-operation among all nations, each should help the other and all should live in peace and prosperity. It is true that they all desire such an atmosphere to prevail in the world. But what we see happening today is just the reverse.

AMERICA'S OBJECTIVE

America desires to send aid to the different countries in Asia. She desires that under her patronage the world may grow strong. She says that she has no selfish motive behind these aids and does it as it is the only way to save the world. But we believe otherwise. We feel that her offer of military aids will certainly endanger the peace of the world. It has made many countries in Asia feel agitated and even angry. The President of America writes to our Prime Minister that if India also desires military aid, he will sympathetically consider her request also.

PAKISTAN'S CONDUCT

Pakistan thought it good to take military aid from America. She thinks that she can become strong thereby.

Of course, one has to think and decide for oneself. India has clearly made it known to the world that she is not prepared at any cost to join in this political gamble. She will not accept any military help from outside. Leaving the path of peace along which she has been all along going, if India imitates Pakistan, she will certainly invite danger not only to herself but to the whole world. Then there will be nothing left with her. She will lose her freedom also. So she decided that she should not fall into this tangle. Our leaders, in particular Pandit Nehru, took the correct stand with a firm determination. We are particularly happy over it. The American President tells us that he desires to give us also military aid without any strings attached to it. Perhaps he may be joking. We can't believe what he professes. We consider the offer as an insult to us.

HOW TO MAKE OURSELVES STRONG

It is not enough if we simply say that we do not want any help from out-side. We have to do our work in right earnest. We have to make our country strong in the real sense. It is wrong to think that a country's strength lies in its military power. A really strong nation can never be a source of danger to any. It can give strength to all other nations of the world. It will certainly inspire them with courage. A nation will become really strong only if it is free from internal conflicts, if it becomes self-sufficient and the people within are united by bonds of love. If we make our country strong like this, whatever be the threats of dangers that may confront us, none of them will cast any shade on us. On the other hand, our greatness will certainly have its good influence on the outside world. Thus if we

strive to make ourselves strong we shall save not only ourselves but the whole world. Of course, God alone can save the world. God will certainly make us as His instruments for the same if by His grace, we keep our heads cool and minds steady and go on demonstrating the strength of Ahimsa (Non-violence), love and satyagraha, continue doing constructive work, and abolish unemployment from our midst by each family doing the needed sacrifice for the same, and live as members of one single family. There is no reason to feel that in this world, violence alone will prevail and there is no escape for us also from it. We are not men without light. We are living beings with the soul within us. It is the master of its surroundings. So if we improve the conditions in our country through just and peaceful means and thus make it strong, we shall be not only making ourselves free from dangers and sufferings but also be saving the other nations of the world.

NO TRUST IN POLITICAL ALLIANCES

I have no faith in power alliances. Nations are making their own political alliances. They won't serve any useful purpose. Alliances with cowards, with men of no moral integrity, whatever be their numerical strength, can never become a powerful force. If we are strong from within, we can develop real power. If we behave as cowards, weaklings, timids bending before tyrants and quarrel amongst ourselves fostering differences of high and low, we can never become a powerful force in this world. A nation with all the above weaknesses is a non-entity, a mere zero. What is the good of such 50 zero-partners forming a comity of nations? If we make ourselves strong we

can be really exerting a moral influence over the whole world and we will be able to make our own nation a great and strong fortress.

OUR OWN IMPERFECTIONS

We have in our midst many weaknesses. There is poverty everywhere. It has to be got rid off. We have to increase production. We have to become responsible workers. We have to get rid of the idleness in us. We have to get over all the caste, sect, and language differences in our midst. In these days there is much of malice and enmity between parties. Untouchability is prohibited, yet it is not wiped off from our midst. It is still living. All this is to be done in the social field.

In the moral sphere also we have much to do. In these days wherever we look we see corruption, drunkenness and obscene cinemas etc. Of course, there can be good cinemas but what we have today are such that would demoralise the life of the people. All these are leading us to ruin. We have to purify the whole atmosphere.

BHOODAN YAGNA: ALL-COMPREHENSIVE PROGRAMME

Bhoo dan Yagna is an all comprehensive movement directed to the reform in all walks of life. Today everyone thinks of himself alone and feels for his self only. But Bhoo dan makes the people think and do just the opposite of what they do now. It makes the people look around and say "I will first think of my neighbour, and if he has no land, I must consider it is my duty to provide him with it". In Bhoo dan, distribution of land is not the only question.

It aims at the moral regeneration of the whole nation in fact. Through it we hope to solve the economic difficulties in our society. With all these hopes I am concentrating all my attention on it. If we succeed in this we are sure to succeed in everything else.

When village industries are encouraged, unemployment will disappear. Cottage industries can never prosper unless the land is equitably distributed. So Bhoodan takes in the programme for the revival of cottage industries also within it.

The great aloofness that we find in society today between the educated and the uneducated will not disappear unless both are made to join in common work. We have to inculcate in our people the habit and delight for doing manual work. The education that our children get now in schools, is devoid of any manual labour. They do not know how to earn their living and how to improve the country's economic conditions. So Shramadan (labour-gifts) is also initiated. This will bring an entire change to the whole life of the country. We have to reclaim and make the waste lands included in some of the gifts offered in Bhoodan, cultivable. Students can join this work and thus offer their share of gift of labour.

I am also claiming a share of the wealth in people's hand, through Sampatti-Dan. Much wealth lies invested in gold and silver. It is wrong to keep wealth dead like this. The nation should get the benefit of it. That is why I ask those people who keep such wealth, to give a share of it for the good of society.

The Third Force or Jana Sakthi

THE TWO FORCES IN THE WORLD

TWO new forces are now working in this world. Two new currents are there. Two conceptions and sentiments are competing and conflicting. The whole situation is shaky. There are many danger spots ready to burst at any time. It may be that they may develop many phases. I am drawing this dreadful picture not with a view to frighten you. We have to bear this in mind when we take every step forward in our work. With an eye on it we have to shape our activities.

CONFLICT BETWEEN HEART AND HEAD

One or two months back some wise and learned men met at Delhi * and had some searching discussions to evaluate the technique and application of non-violence. It is reported that Shri Rajendra Babu stated there that no nation in the world had yet the courage to declare that it could function without the strength of military force and further he expressed regret that, inspite of the fact that the people of India heard with their own ears straight from Gandhiji's mouth his teachings and did attempt some work in that line, they could not do so. Our great leader Pandit Nehru said on many occasions that no problem of the world could be solved by the use of military force. He has no belief in violence. His heart believes in non-violence. Even then in this peculiar situation of the world he had to accept the

* International Seminar on Gandhian outlook and Technique for World Peace.

responsibility to increase and strengthen the military strength of the country. In such a strange state of the world we are living now.

The heart believes in one thing but the brain directs action in a different way. We desire that non-violence should spread not only in India but in the whole world ; we shall not fear each other ; we shall love one another. The heart believes fully that love alone will win and bring success. It tells us that no problem of the world can be solved by violence. It knows that if one problem is solved, ten other problems emerge out of it.

COMMUNITY PROJECT

The Government desires to introduce the Community Projects in the 5 to 7 lakhs of our villages. They are now started in a few villages. They hope that when this work is extended to other villages also, unemployment will be wiped off and the country will become prosperous. But if war breaks out tomorrow I doubt whether a single one of these projects will continue working. Even they who started it cannot say whether these projects will then be continued or not. Their brain will at once fret and fume and will say "Now the chief work of the day is the defence of the country". Even if we sit on those seats of responsibility it cannot be said that something different will be done, for they are the seats of glamour and whoever that ascends it will in turn be forced to think in a narrow limited and consciously helpless circle. Even the great nations of America and Russia get frightened. Then how can the less strong nations of Pakistan and Hindusthan feel otherwise ?

JANA SAKTHI

People ask me on many occasions why I remain outside and why I don't take up the responsibility of state administration. My answer is this: If two bulls are already yoked to a cart, of what help will it be if a third one is also added. If I remain outside, I can clear the path and give a better tract to proceed on. Those who have taken up administrative responsibility tell us 'please don't do the work which we are doing. What is lacking in us, please fill up'. They desire our help. From this we have to understand that we have to work to create that strength in the people which I call *Janasakthi* which is the very foundation of the new order of society which we desire to usher in.

THE THIRD FORCE

What is this third force or *Jana Sakthi*? It will be that force which is hostile to violent force. Yet it is different from the police force (*Dhanda sakthi*) of the State. This police force has, of course, got a fraction of violence in it. But I don't desire to call it a violent force because it is the whole society that has entrusted this power in the hands of the government. Hence it is not a mere violent force, but something apart from it. It is the penal power of the State. The Sarvodaya Sevakas would be understanding their duty and fulfilling their responsibility if only they create an atmosphere, which will counteract the forces of violence in war and will reduce the occasions for the use of the State's police force. This is what the people expect us to do.

LEGISLATION OR MENTAL TRANSFORMATION?

Many ask me why I don't make a demand on the Government to bring in legislation and to distribute land without any compensation. My answer to them is this: Brother, I don't stand in the way of legislation. I have taken this one step and in this itself I have not yet fully succeeded. If I have succeeded in achieving 75% or even 50% result then I can claim that the favourable atmosphere is created for legislation. One thing is that I should see that no obstruction for legislation should come in and the second thing is that I must pave the way clear for it. Without attempting them, if I take another step and go on repeating that without legislation this work will not succeed, then it means I do not know my duty. Swadharma demands that without the aid of legislation I should create a transformation in the mental outlook of the people who themselves may distribute land among themselves. Is it because of any law or rule that the mothers are feeding their babies? The power of love in the hearts of men makes life happy and full. Man has faith in love. He is born in love. He is nursed through love. Having realized this force of love if I go on repeating legislation, I will not be creating the *Jana sakthi*,—the non-violent sanction of the masses.

The Sarvodaya Sevaks' real service is therefore to build up the strength and power of the people. This force, I don't say, is the counter force to 'police force' of the State. It is only the opposite force to violence.

If we desire to solve the land problem by ourselves, then our method should be distinct from that of the State which would do it through "police force". Of course, wealth may increase. Our goal is not the production of wealth alone.

PROPAGATION OF IDEAS

There will be two aspects to the plan of our work. The one is our effort to develop the power of thinking in people and the other to enable them to manage their own affairs.

Power of thinking means and includes that power to understand oneself and make others understand the principles and objectives behind every act. Without understanding we should not blindly do anything; if we do so we will be put to grief. We should not make others accept our ideas without their understanding them. On no account we should impose our ideas on others. We should only discuss things and give counsel. Our Samaj is only a sevaks' association which stands on the foundation of ideas and thoughts. The sevak's basic function is to propagate the ideas by consultation and advice. In 'Koran' the true devotees are described as those who do work by discussion, counsel and persuasion. I will be happy if our sevaks carry on our work in a similar manner. In this method lies our real strength. It is the Siva Sakthi that we should develop and create. So like the ever flowing mountain streams, let the sevaks wander from place to place and constantly

mix and move with the people with firm faith in the ideals. Let them do propaganda with never-failing enthusiasm, patience and persuasion. Let them understand that this is the weapon in their hands.

DECENTRALISATION OF POWER

Our second work is the distribution of power and decentralisation of administration and management. The administrative power and strength should not remain centralised at one place. They should be developed in each and every village, so that each village can say and decide which things should come in there and which should not. If any village desires that no mill-pressed oil should be brought within its limits and wants to ban it, then it should have the authority and power to order and enforce a ban.

The entire machinery of the Government should be so decentralized—each village empowered and capable to look after its own affairs—that it will make an outsider even to doubt whether the State Government is functioning at all and whether there actually exists a governing power in India. If this is achieved, then we can say that our State has become a non-violent State.

VILLAGE PLANNING INSTEAD OF NATIONAL PLANNING

With this objective clear before us we should proceed to work in the villages and establish village Raj. We

should make the village people strong enough to stand on their own legs so that they could decide what they shall grow and produce within their area, what all things only should be allowed entry within and what all should be prohibited. If the State does not agree or unable to act even if it desires to do so, the villagers should then have the courage to desist and prove their strength through their self-sufficiency. It is impossible that there can function in Delhi a brain, so big and mighty, which can manage and administer all the affairs of all the villages throughout the land and see that everyone of its acts is for the benefit of all. It is for this that we desire that there should be Village planning instead of National planning. National planning should mean Village planning. All our activities should be to bring about decentralisation. It is for this reason we desire the distribution of land in the villages.

WE CANNOT LOSE THE GREAT WEALTH OF THE NATION

In these days people have begun to talk about the 'maximum extent of individual holding', and about 'ceiling' whenever questions of land are discussed. Of course the advent of Bhoodan movement has created the atmosphere. We have to agree first to give some land to everyone—the minimum, at least. All the wage-earners of today are labourers under other's supervision. The cart is moving, but we don't say it is the moving force. Our labour population is working only with their hands and legs. They have got brains, and they have hearts. Let them use them when they work. This is the thing we desire them to do. Suppose, that much

intelligence as is in them is abandoned, tell me, what other treasure have we got with us in the country. We have nothing else. And if we do not make use of it, it will be a great loss to our nation. Hence we have to make the best use of what intelligence is there. If we give them education, certainly their brain will sharpen. So we have to educate them and draw a scheme to that effect. In any such scheme, distribution of land to them is the basic principle.

FIVE CRORES OF ACRES OF BHOODAN

At least 5 crores of acres of land should be transferred to the landless labourers before 1957. If all of us concentrate our full attention and energy on this, it can be achieved. By 'us' I mean not the Sarvodaya Samaj sevaks alone, but the Congress men, the Praja Socialists and every one else who accepts the ideal behind the mission. We should achieve success in solving the land problem mainly through *Jana-sakthi*—the strength and initiative of the general public.

WE WANT RAMA-RAVANA FIGHT AND NOT BHISHMA-ARJUNA FIGHT

Success in Bhoodan will make the future election, not a fight between parties who have good men on either side. We do not want the Bishma-Arjuna fight, but we want the Rama-Ravana fight. Today there are good people in every party. Could it not be possible to bring all the good people to one side? A common programme which will bring all the good men together to agree on the fundamentals, will dissolve all the differences. Now the

Socialists tell me that I have seized up their programme. I admit and so ask them to help me. The Congress men say that this programme is very good. I would like them also to help me. The Jana Sangh people claim that this work is consistent with Indian culture. If these various parties accept this programme and work for it, there will not be much conflict in the coming election and the best will be elected. If this would happen it would ensure a very strong government. Such hopes I have in Bhoodan. We should not feel content with anything less than 5 crores of acres of land.

SARVODAYA WORKERS AND "THIRD FORCE"

In conclusion let me give you one word of caution. Our work is not on party lines or on sectarian principles. The word 'Sarvodaya-wala' is a misnomer. You should not use it. We are nothing more than mere human beings as anybody else. The Sarvodaya Samaj is not an organisation in the ordinary sense and we should not allow it to degenerate into a sectarian or party group. We should avoid the use of such terms that such and such a person is a Socialist, such and such an individual is a Congressite and such and such a worker is a Sarvodaya-wala. May be, others think in terms of party labels; let them call themselves so, as it may be advantageous to them. Ours is not a party. We belong to the 'Third Force'. By 'Third Force' I mean not that 'force' which international politics calls as that power which stands aloof from both the American Bloc and the Russian Bloc. By 'Third Force' I mean that 'Force' which is opposed to *Himsa Sakshi* (Force of

Violence) and which is distinct and different from *Dhanda Sakthi* or State-Force. The first is the 'Violent Force'; the second is the 'Government Force' and the third in the '*Jana Sakthi*' (People's Force). We should make this 'third force' strong and keep free from party politics and sectarianism. To achieve it we should mix and move with the people and identify ourselves entirely one with them. We should always bear in mind that we are simply human beings as any one else.

VINOBA AND HIS MISSION

BY

SURESH RAMABHAI

With a Foreward by DR. S. RADHAKRISHNAN

AND

Introduction by SHRI JAIPRAKASH NARAIN

(Published by the Sarva Seva Sangh)

This gives a complete history and progress of the Bhoodan Yagna and its philosophy with copious extracts from Acharya Vinoba's speeches till April 1954.

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Towards A State-Free Society

DEMOCRACY has been on experiment in the world for about a century. It has been countenancing many conflicts with the several prevailing forms of Government.

With the advent of this new political thought many parties began to appear on the scene. Differences began to arise among the thinkers on the one hand and the statesmen on the other, as regards the ideological approach as well as actual working. Ideological difference is of course a healthy sign of life and it is welcome. But if such differences lead to party differences and divisions, the workers will become less concerned with the ideal and more concerned with the party organisation, its set-up, discipline and propaganda. This has resulted in a great deal of fuss and furore in the political field throughout the world.

One need not worry much about this sad state of political affairs if the field is narrow and circumscribed. Today it has become so extensive that it has begun to encroach and engulf all aspects of human life in society. In such a large field where rivalry exists, not merely in the different ideological approaches, but also in the conflicting attitudes, practices and procedures, the evolution and progress of human mind will get arrested and hampered.

Hence my attempt is to create a band of Sevaks (workers) which will not have any party label. It will be above all sects, parties, isms, conventions and

practices. It will be an assembly of pure, impartial and free-thinking individuals who will serve people as man to man. You may call them a set of workers, or an assembly of self-less servants, or even an association of ascetics; my attempt is in this direction alone.

In every country there are people who are known as 'humanitarians'. They feel for their fellow-men. Moved by kindness they take a compassionate attitude on those who suffer and serve them in order to give relief. But they do not think deeply about all aspects of life. They keep apart from politics and social science. Mere sympathetic and humanitarian considerations are the motive force in them. Humanitarian work is indeed high and good. It is beneficial to society and helpful in elevating the human mind. Therefore it is quite welcome.

But I will not be satisfied with mere humanitarian service. The band of workers I have in view will engage themselves not only in humanitarian service, but will think of all aspects of human life and serve mankind in all walks of life. They will yearn and work to transform the politics of the State into the politics of the people. They will endeavour to remove all the bitterness that is there today in society and establish the peoples' justice. In short, they will have a clear understanding that their Dharma enjoins them not only to do philanthropic work but to serve mankind as a whole in all walks of life. They will place before the people the defects and vices that they notice in the different parties and among the officials of the State. They will welcome and respect whatever is good in them. All their efforts will be directed to obliterate all party differences and to

establish a society transcending all party affiliations and labels. This is not a new State policy; neither do I desire to name it as such for the State itself will get merged in the general society. What we call now 'the State' will get so decentralized that in the end it will ultimately wither away.

This process of decentralization shall begin from even today. The centralized power will get distributed by degrees which in turn will enter and permeate into every individual with the result the ruling authority will vest in the hands of every one. Each individual will then himself become the State as well as the subject. The ruler and the ruled will have met and merged in the individual. 'I am my own governor, and I am my own servant. Every one else will try to point out my defects and mistakes; still they will all co-operate with me in all my good acts. I too will point out with gentleness their errors and co-operate with them in all their good actions. Yet I am my own master and my own servant; and they will be their own masters and servants. All of us are brothers, colleagues and friends'. All of us are born for the same end. This does not mean that there shall not be any difference in our points of view. It means that there should be unity of heart though not unity at intellectual level.

The power to feel is equal in all. It pertains to the heart. Such virtues as generosity, renunciation, sacrifice, kindness, love, friendship can all be there in equal degrees in all hearts. Equal faith in all these every one should have and that will bring in the heart unity.

The Economics of Sampatti-Dan

NECESSITY OF SAMPATTI-DAN

I had in mind the idea of Sampatti-dan Yagna even when I started Bhoodan. Now the stage to distribute lands has come and it is quite necessary we should start in right earnest the Sampatti-dan Yagna. Ploughs and seeds have to be necessarily supplied to all the landless poor so that they may begin work.

ERADICATION OF POVERTY

It is in towns I wish to carry on this Sampatti-dan movement on a large scale. I appeal to all—from the ministers and merchants down to the poor orderlies—to contribute their mite to this. They should do it with the permission and consent of their family members. No gift short of the dignity and status of the donor be accepted. It should be received only from those alone who really feel that they should consider the poor as a member of their own family. Poor people may give only little, yet that has to be received, for it creates a real sense of Dharma in them. Gifts through articles instead of actual cash, are the best forms of Dan. In the purchase of khadi, half of the price paid is in fact an indirect form of gift to the poor artisans. Such a gift is called a “Gupta-dan” (hidden gift).

GUPTA-DAN

Gupta-dan is considered to be the best. The beauty of it lies in that neither the donor feels the pride of it, nor the receiver suffers from the humiliation behind. Expenditures in connection with pujas, *sraddha* ceremonies

and travels should be stopped. They will not in anyway advance our Dharma.

I appeal to one and all in the country to take a vow to buy only such articles as are produced with the hands of the poor in our villages. Such purchases will be the purest of all gifts. It creates the bond of love between the purchaser and the producer. If you buy Rs. 100 worth of khadi, you are indirectly making a gift of Rs. 50 i. e. half the price you pay, to the poor producer. So you can be considered as one who has contributed a gift of Rs. 50 to this Sampatti-dan Yagna. This applies not only to khadi but to all other articles made with the hands of the poor. Thus it enables every individual, though poor, to contribute his share to this Sampatti-dan. But to the rich I appeal to give at least one-sixth of their wealth. They can give even more.

THE THREE MAIN PURPOSES

For the time being these are the three main purposes for which this Sampatti-dan will be utilized:— (1) To supply implements and seeds etc. to the poor who will be put in possession of lands under the distribution scheme. The major portion of the fund will be spent for this. (2) To meet the expenditure to maintain workers in villages. Our plan is that for every seven villages there shall be one worker who will spend a day in each village in every week. If this scheme materializes there will be a number of Loka-Sevaks (those who serve the people) in India. (3) To propagate Sarvodaya literature and the ideals of dharma among the people in a simple way. As work proceeds and if other items come in, they can be incorporated.

DONOR TO ACT AS THE TRUSTEE

The donor himself will spend the money on these items only. Towards the end of the year he will submit his accounts to us. If any alterations are to be made we will instruct him and he will do so. Why I have fixed a portion of the income alone instead of a fixed amount is because, when the donor's income dwindles, he needs pay less only and if it becomes nil, he need not pay anything at all. This will continue for the life of the donor.

'RENOUNCING THOU SHALT EAT'

"*Thyektena Bhunjeetha*" is the principle behind the gift. This means "renouncing thou shalt eat".

There is much of the lust in us to-day. So first we should give and then only eat. If we cultivate this habit of giving to others before enjoying, and understand the principle behind it, the poor in the villages will never suffer and every home in each village will be a bank from which they can easily draw.

PURE FOOD

In this way an atmosphere of dharma will be created all round. Every child would say that its father used to eat only after feeding the poor. This culture if imbibed from childhood will make everyone grow into a generous and sacrificing citizen ever ready to die for his country. He becomes strong, courageous and devoted to duty because he is nursed by the purest of food. He upholds the cultural tradition handed down to us from ancient days.

JYOTHI BURNING IN EVERYONE

There is a *jyothi* (light) burning in every individual. It cannot be extinguished however much one may try. There are many kinds of desires and impulses in man. Here he offers lands as gift while there he evicts the cultivator. Persons offering lands to this Yagna, at the same time evicting tenants, are committing a fraud unto themselves. Man is an enlightened being. The real essence in him tells him to make gifts. The surrounding circumstances make him forget himself for the time being and do evil unto others. He should disentangle himself from such influences. He cannot do it all on a sudden. He should, step by step, train to obey the good conscience within him. If he practises it day by day, there will come a time when he will succeed and grow full and true unto himself.

MAN-ONLY A TRUSTEE OF THE WEALTH

There is an independent basic principle behind this Sampatti-dan, apart from the idea to render help to the landless peasants. Just as land cannot be the exclusive property of anyone like air and light, wealth also cannot be owned by anyone in particular. None can be the Lord of Bhumi (Earth) or the Lord of Laxmi (wealth). Laxmi is the mother. If wealth accumulates in the hands of any, it is not due his own efforts alone; it is due to the collective effort of all and so it belongs to all in society. Individuals are only the means to produce wealth and each holds it for the benefit of all. The father never thinks that whatever he earns is entirely his and due to his sole effort. He works for the family and he can find happi-

ness only if all in the family co-operate with him. Thus every member of the family gets the right on the family wealth. Today man cares for the limited circle of his family alone. If he ponders a little deep he will find that the entire wealth in his hands belongs to the society in general. We are only the guardians of wealth and a part out of it alone we can take for ourselves and that only in the form of a *prosad* from the Lord of all to whom it is offered. This is the basic principle behind this Sampatti-dan.

OUR STATE CONSTITUTION SHOULD GROW

People say, that to refute private ownership of property, is against the State's Constitution. This Constitution is not a heaven-sent gift. It is a creation of man and so when man's ideals undergo changes the Constitution also will have to be changed. It is not at all desired by me that this change should be brought about by force. It is my right to make people understand the ideal and it is the duty of people to grasp them. Does it mean that people go against the Constitution if they understand this principle? The Constitution should grow and expand day by day.

DIFFERENTIAL TREATMENT SHOULD CEASE

The sense of ownership should cease to exist. The idea in our people that they should get more money because they have more intellect, more strength and they are doing a work of a superior nature, is wrong. Suppose Thulasidas is living today and his literature goes into hands of another man, and that man offers

him Rs. 5,000 for it. Will he be ready to accept it? I don't mean to say that people should not get anything for the work they do. I say it should not be in terms of money. I have often asked why the President's emolument is more than that of the Prime Minister. It is understandable if it can be proved that a man occupying a higher status is more hungry than the one in a lower status. One friend related to us a very good example. He said: "We wear on the head a cap costing eight annas and on the leg shoes worth eight rupees. Does it mean from this that our foot has a higher status than our head?"

ASSESSMENT OF VALUES

One man saved the life of another drowning in a river. Can we value his service in terms of money, say two annas for the labour of ten minutes? True this act of saving his life involves manual labour, but it is selfless and full of the love of humanity which can never be assessed in rupee value. The mother does service for the children. Can it be evaluated in terms of money? The teacher teaches the student and transforms even the brute into a man. How can we assess its value in rupees? The brother does service, the father does service, the sister does service. Do they do it for money? If anyone asks me as to how many seconds are there in a mile I cannot answer him. I can only say that there are so many furlongs in a mile. It is impossible to equate furlongs or yards to seconds. In the same way it is impossible to convert the values of moral service and dharma in terms of rupees, annas, pies. All men who do service with faith and devotion not

expecting anything in return for the same, would attain salvation. They command respect from all and become blessed by God. Moral values can never be measured in terms of material values. I find delight in service. How can I assess its price? On what basis will you assess it?

MISER — THE FATHER OF THEFT

Today society considers theft a sin. Yet some people commit theft. It is bad to steal and society condemns it. It should also recognise hoarding too as a sin like theft. Both are sins alike. The miser is the father of theft. If these are no misers and hoarders, there will be no theft at all in this world.

REAL UNDERSTANDING

Suppose anyone offers one-sixth of his earning for life. Still he cannot be taken to have fully understood the ideal behind this Sampatti-dan Yagna. In case he owns any particular industrial concern, he should also consider all the labourers under him as co-sharers along with him and should give each his share as a partner. Thereafter he should offer if anything remains for the benefit of society. If he does this he can be considered as one who has understood this principle and as a man of real sacrifice. Whatever little he takes for himself is the prosad of the Yagna. Gandhiji keenly desired that everyone should consider himself as the trustee of his wealth. Through this Sampatti-dan programme that principle can now be realized by us. This is real economics and is the recent science in economics.

ALL INDIA BHOODAN

RECEIVED AND DISTRIBUTED TILL
10th DECEMBER 1954

Province	Land received in acres	No. of Dan-patras	Land distributed in acres	No. of families
1. Bihar ..	21,27,268	2,41,712	1,616	944
2. Uttar Pradesh ..	5,16,819	15,258	65,997	22,262
3. Rajasthan ..	3,25,374	2,192	5,842	1,364
4. Hyderabad ..	1,03,706	3,815	21,027	4,559
5. Utkal ..	1,15,207	38,397	768	214
6. Madya Pradesh ..	80,481	13,639	7,638	1,724
7. Madya Bharath ..	62,412	5,377	..	..
8. Saurashtra ..	41,000	15,000	..	..
9. Gujarat ..	36,170	7,760	942	251
10. Tamil Nad ..	28,259	4,774	316	115
11. Andhra ..	20,361	672	..	..
12. Kerala ..	28,032	1,200	..	..
13. Maharashtra ..	15,480	769	..	..
14. Punjab ..	10,143	3,008	..	..
15. Delhi ..	9,245	249	58	22
16. Vindya Pradesh ..	5,656	1,050	331	150
17. Mysore ..	4,390	1,875	..	..
18. Bengal ..	6,889	2,631	254	171
19. Himachal Pradesh ..	1,900	66	..	..
20. Karnatak ..	2,180	239	239	..
21. Assam ..	1,692	..	..	..
22. Bombay ..	123	6	..	..
	35,42,787	3,59,689	1,04,968	31,776

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